



UW HEALTH · PATIENT EDUCATION

Lab work for adrenal nodules

Some adrenal nodules can produce extra hormones. These tests help check for that. Your doctor may order one or all of them based on your situation.



Schedule one morning appointment to get all labs done at the same time. All three blood tests can be drawn together at a single visit. Aim for an 8:00 AM draw.



Dexamethasone suppression test (DST) — cortisol test

Requires a step the night before

Checks for: too much cortisol (stress hormone)

WHAT YOU DO

Night before — 11:00 PM exactly

- Take 1 mg of dexamethasone (usually two 0.5 mg tablets together)
- Timing matters — set an alarm for 11:00 PM
- Take with water, juice, or milk (milk may help prevent heartburn)

Next morning — 8:00 AM

- Arrive at the lab by 7:45–7:55 AM
- Blood draw must be as close to 8:00 AM as possible
- It is best to schedule your lab appointment in advance

IMPORTANT TIPS

- Do not miss the morning blood draw — both steps must be completed for the test to work

WHAT THE RESULTS MEAN

Normal Low cortisol level

See a surgeon Higher cortisol may mean overproduction by your adrenal gland — a surgeon will discuss next steps

EATING & DRINKING

- You can eat and drink normally



Aldosterone & renin

Blood pressure hormone test

Checks for: hormone causes of high blood pressure

WHAT YOU DO

- Morning blood draw — done once

EATING & DRINKING

- Eat and drink normally
- Keep your regular salt intake — do not cut back before this test
- Take your blood pressure medications as normal

WHAT THE RESULTS MEAN

See a surgeon High aldosterone may mean too much hormone is elevating your blood pressure



If labs are abnormal, we may ask you to repeat the test after holding certain blood pressure medications



Plasma metanephrines

Adrenaline hormone test

Checks for: rare adrenal tumors causing high blood pressure

WHAT YOU DO

- Single blood draw

EATING & DRINKING

- Eat and drink normally

IMPORTANT TIPS

- Physical stress and some medications can affect results — let your doctor know what you take

WHAT THE RESULTS MEAN

See a surgeon High levels may indicate a pheochromocytoma — a surgeon will discuss next steps



Before your tests

Quick reminders

BRING TO THE LAB

- Photo ID and insurance card
- Your doctor's lab order (if given one)
- List of current medications

TELL YOUR DOCTOR IF YOU

- Take blood pressure medications
- Take steroids or hormone medications
- Are feeling unusually stressed or unwell on the day of testing



Questions? Contact your UW Health provider's office before your test date. You can also reach the UW Health lab directly for scheduling, walk-in hours, and location information.